

We Need Early Education Urgently

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Opinion Brief

Early Childhood Education (ECE) is defined as the formal education and care of young children, typically ages 0-5 years old. This type of education takes place typically in daycares, preschools, and sometimes even home-based centers, before children go off to primary school. Education in these settings is based on the understanding that during these years there are a critical period of development, skills, attitudes, and learning patterns for the young child. There are plenty of positive long-term benefits for children that attend these types of centers. Improved school readiness, higher rates of high school graduation, graduating from college, and improved social behaviors are some examples (American Public University, 2024). ECE services also provide a key crucial support system for families in developing and nurturing their child's development.

Around the country that is a lack of ECE services for low-income families. A lack of these services is called a 'childcare desert' where there aren't enough slots for each child. There is a cycle of disadvantages that society keeps perpetuating. Children that do not attend ECE have a higher chance of dropping out of school and never going to college. Education is a key steppingstone to getting a high paying job, living in an environmentally friendly place, and living well socially. There is a lost potential that will have a ripple effect individually and as a society that we have yet to understand. Educators, parents, and other such professionals have been sounding the alarm for years. Policy makers, politicians, and other individuals in power have yet to solve this systematic issue. There has been a loss in federal funding, due to the political climate, high staff burnout/turnover, and low staff wages.

Let's take an example. Oregon State University (OSU) is a local 4-year university located in the state of Oregon. Throughout the OSU affiliated campuses, such as Corvallis, Newport, Bend, and Portland, they have shut down two of their most prominent early education centers. Just recently in the OSU-Cascades campus located in Bend, Oregon, closed their early education center called Little Kits. This closure has heavily impacted OSU educators, employees, and

students. The daycare had a dual purpose. First was to provide much needed daycare slots for parents, and secondly to provide training for future educators as part of the university's ECE program. OSU-Cascades is in central Oregon, which has a high childcare rate, especially for infant and toddler care (Martínez, 2026).

This example alone shows how impactful ECE is for parents, and how a lack of affordable and available resources heavily strains families and communities. This can contribute to high stress, loss of job and income revenue, and reduced social interactions. Structured ECE policies, and dependent on how they are implemented can help lessen the burden on parents.

Many individuals argue that ECE educators and professionals are just glorified babysitters. That parents should just stay home and take care of their kids. ECE is not needed and should not be funded. While that argument has been heard around the country, it is not realistic. ECE educators and professionals are hard-working and are building the foundational skills for the next generation. With the cost of living being so high, one of the parents being able to stay home and take care of the kids is not realistic.

There needs to be some alternative option or form for parents to use. Something that can be easily implemented and utilized. Applications that are easy to understand and fill out. Greater and broader income eligibility for low-income parents.

Works Cited

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